



U.K. EDITION

THE 2026 INDUSTRY PULSE REPORT

December 2025

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FIELD DATE

October 2025

PARTICIPATION

N=220 U.K. digital media experts who use programmatic advertising

- Advertisers (n=84)
- Agencies (n=81)
- Publishers and platforms (n=55)

Integral Ad Science (IAS) partnered with [YouGov](#) to survey U.K. digital media experts from both the buy- and sell-sides to understand their perspectives on media challenges lying ahead and opportunities they will seek to harness in 2026.

In this annual report, we deep dive into the trends, technologies, and solutions that will shape digital media and advertising in 2026, directly from top industry professionals.

THE NEXT CHAPTER OF DIGITAL MEDIA

2026 marks a turning point in digital advertising. As the boundaries between channels blur — and AI reshapes how content is created, consumed, and measured — industry experts are redefining what quality means in this new era.

Here's what media experts are anticipating in 2026 →



SOCIAL AND DIGITAL VIDEO ARE AT THE CENTER OF MEDIA EVOLUTION

- **87% of media experts** cite digital video as a top priority over display and audio
- **89% say brand safety and suitability** of the social influencer/creator will be an important consideration when advertising adjacent to digital video content



MARKETERS ARE LEANING INTO AI'S OPPORTUNITIES DESPITE CHALLENGES

- **50% of media experts** express excitement with AI developments in digital media and are looking forward to opportunities to advertise alongside AI generated content
- **56% of media experts** cite ad adjacency to content generated by AI as a top media challenge in the coming year



MEDIA QUALITY IS A CORNERSTONE OF PERFORMANCE

- For advertisers and agencies, media quality remains a defining priority. Ad content adjacency dominates, cited by **78%** of respondents
- **40% say publishers** say their top priority will be cutting the carbon footprint of programmatic advertising

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01

TOP MEDIA CHALLENGES AND OPPORTUNITIES

As digital media evolves, advertisers and publishers alike are recognising that marketing opportunities, like those on social media and digital video, come with complexity. The rise of generative AI, made-for-advertising (MFA) sites, and risks of ad adjacency to unsuitable content all threaten media quality.

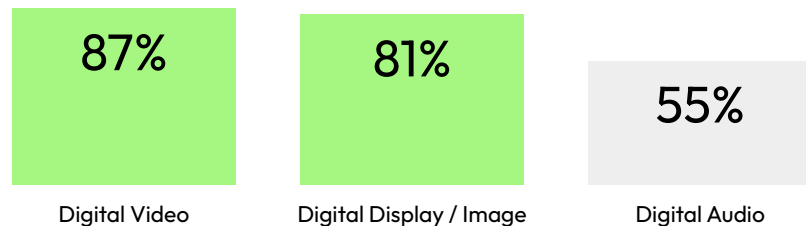
The industry's challenge lies in balancing digital innovation with control — ensuring every impression drives trust and performance.

[HERE'S WHAT THE EXPERTS THINK →](#)

TOP MEDIA PRIORITIES IN 2026

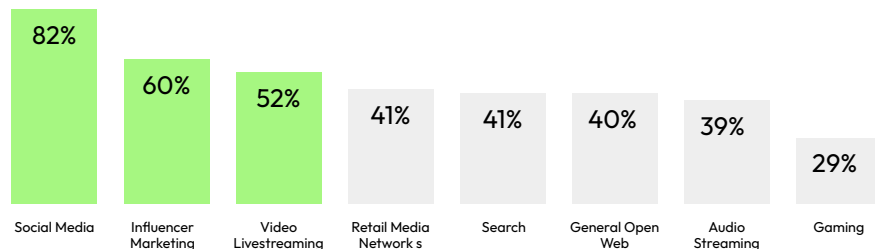
TOP MEDIA CHALLENGES
AND OPPORTUNITIES

Top Digital Formats



Media experts are prioritising digital video and display as top **digital formats** while digital audio lags behind

Top Digital Environments



Social media remains the top priority **digital environment** among media experts, followed by influencer marketing

MEDIA TYPES FACING THE BIGGEST CHALLENGES

TOP MEDIA CHALLENGES
AND OPPORTUNITIES



41%

SOCIAL MEDIA

Social media continues to face serious challenges, especially around ad content adjacencies with potentially increasing risky content on platforms.



31%

DIGITAL VIDEO

Digital video continues to grow in volume and become increasingly interconnected with social media. Adjacencies to AI generated content pose potential threats.



29%

DIGITAL DISPLAY

Digital display continues to face challenges. Display advertising remains vulnerable to fraud and made-for-advertising (MFA) sites, as well as ad content adjacencies.



27%

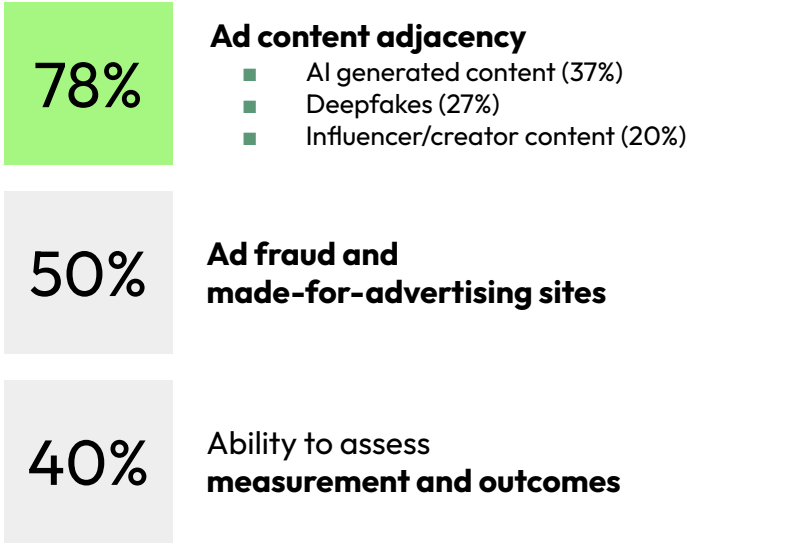
INFLUENCER MARKETING

Brand safety and suitability concerns with influencer and creator content are becoming a unique challenge to the industry.

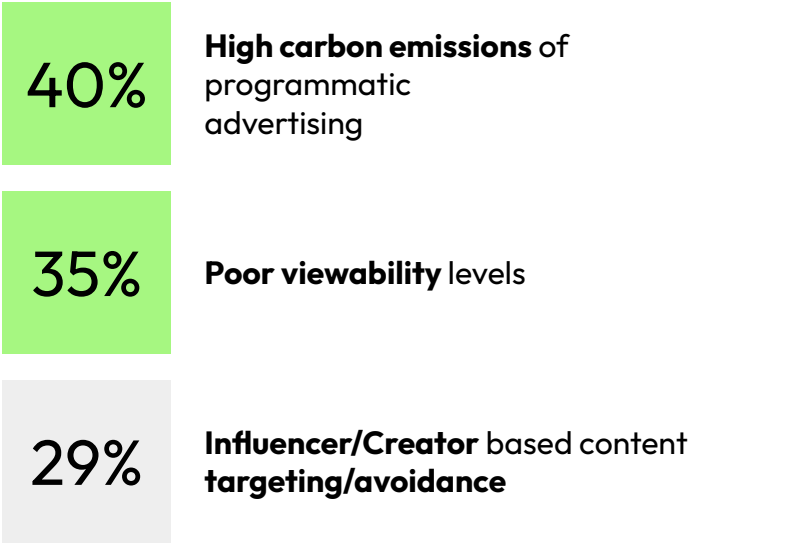
TOP ANTICIPATED MEDIA CHALLENGES BY COMPANY TYPE

TOP MEDIA CHALLENGES
AND OPPORTUNITIES

Brands & Agencies

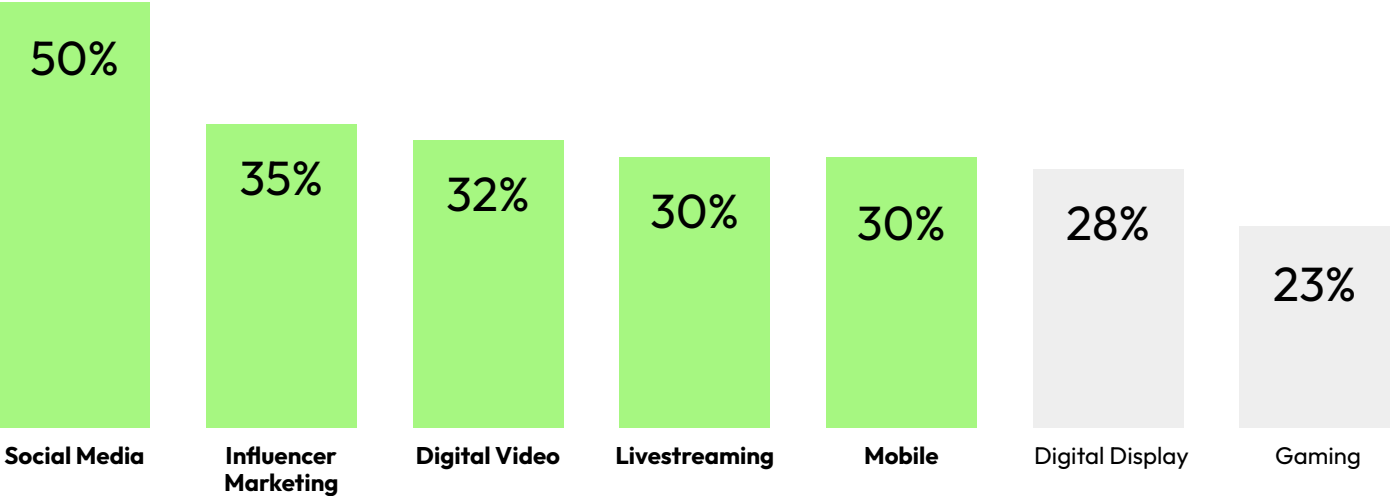


Publishers & Platforms



MEDIA TYPES WITH THE MOST POTENTIAL FOR INNOVATION

Top Media Types with Potential for Innovation



02

THE RISE OF GENERATIVE AI

Generative AI has shifted from experimentation to an essential tool, reshaping how advertisers and publishers create, target, and optimize content.

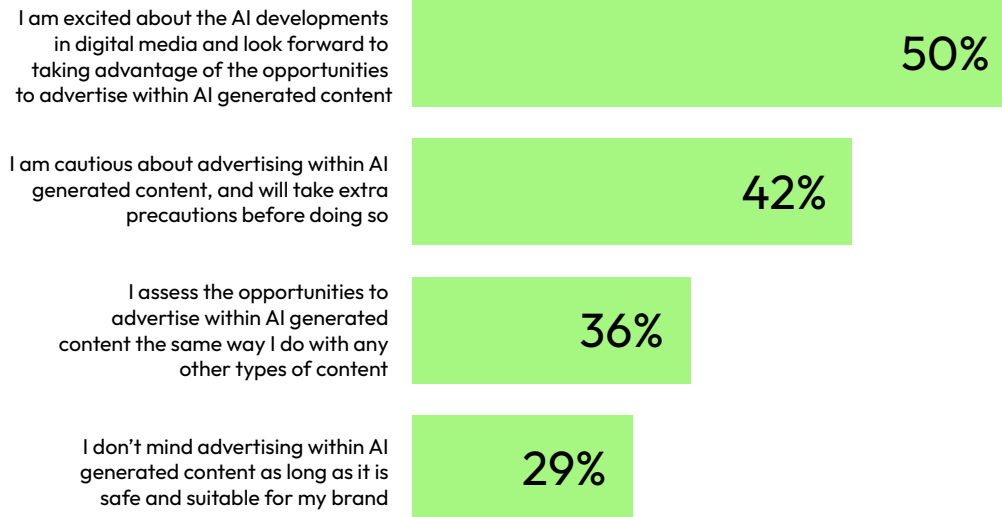
As we look to next year, generative AI's potential to bring speed, personalization, and scale to campaigns undeniable — but its power also introduces new risks.

[HERE'S WHAT THE EXPERTS THINK →](#)

MEDIA EXPERTS GENERALLY FEEL POSITIVELY ABOUT ADVERTISING NEAR GENERATIVE AI CONTENT

THE RISE OF
GENERATIVE AI

Attitudes towards Advertising Adjacencies with AI Generated Content



WHAT THIS MEANS FOR MARKETERS

Marketers can expect an expanding opportunity to advertise alongside AI-generated content, as industry experts increasingly view these environments as viable and even exciting. Still, success will hinge on pairing this innovation with quality controls to ensure AI-driven environments align with brand values.

NONETHELESS, MEDIA EXPERTS ARE APPROACHING WITH CAUTION, AND ARE DISCERNING OF ADJACENCIES TO UNSUITABLE GEN AI CONTENT

56%

of media experts cite ad adjacency to content generated by AI as a top media challenge in the coming year

40%

of media experts cite that increasing levels of AI generated content not suitable for brands and ad adjacency to this content is a serious threat to media quality

42%

of media experts are cautious about advertising within AI generated content and will take extra precautions before doing so

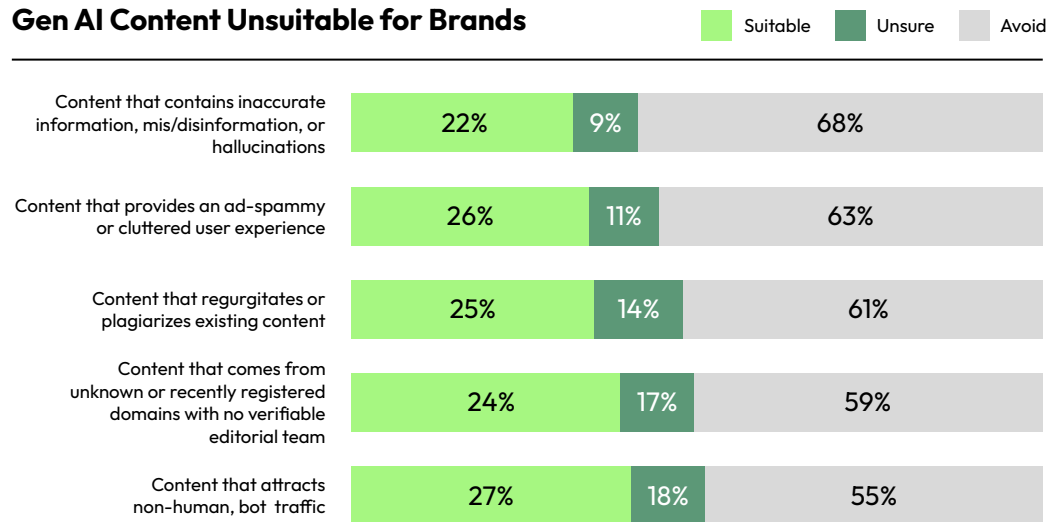


WHAT THIS MEANS FOR MARKETERS

Despite growing enthusiasm for AI, the rise of unsuitable or unverified AI-generated content increases reputational risk, making brand safety and suitability more essential than ever. Adopting a clear suitability framework and prioritizing media transparency is key to confidently capitalize on AI-driven opportunities.

GEN AI CONTENT THAT CONTAINS INACCURATE INFORMATION OR PROVIDES A CLUTTERED USER EXPERIENCE RANKS HIGHEST AMONG CONTENT THAT MEDIA EXPERTS WOULD AVOID

Gen AI Content Unsuitable for Brands



WHAT THIS MEANS FOR MARKETERS

Not all AI-generated content is created equal, and marketers will need to distinguish between high- and low-quality environments as AI production grows.

Prioritising AI classification tools and robust avoidance strategies will help ensure brands maintain trust while still benefiting from AI-enabled reach.

Avoid content you deem risky or unsuitable with IAS's Context Control Avoidance solution, which leverages our industry-leading semantic intelligence engine.



MADE-FOR-ADVERTISING AND AD CLUTTER AVOIDANCE

Avoid all MFA and ad clutter sites as identified by IAS's AI-driven MFA site classification technology.

Our MFA measurement and optimisation model supports the ANA's definition of MFA and has been trained against Jounce Media's widely adopted list of MFA domains, resulting in the **industry's first pressure-tested solution for detecting and blocking MFA at scale.**

03

SOCIAL MEDIA

Social media remains at the heart of digital media, fueling cultural conversations and shaping consumer decisions. It's also one of the most innovative digital environments, as influencer marketing, in-feed video, and generative AI content continue to grow and thrive.

In 2026, advertisers are scrutinizing the environments where their messages appear, seeking brand-safe spaces that both foster consumer trust and enhance brand relevancy.

[HERE'S WHAT THE EXPERTS THINK →](#)

MEASURING MEDIA QUALITY ON SOCIAL MEDIA WILL REMAIN IMPORTANT IN ENSURING ADVERTISING MADE AN IMPACT

SOCIAL MEDIA

Media Quality Considerations on Social Media

Viewability is an important metric when assessing social media campaigns

85%

Measuring **attention** on social media ads will be important to evaluate campaign

85%

Insufficient transparency in terms of media quality metrics within social media platforms will negatively impact media spend

71%



WHAT THIS MEANS FOR MARKETERS

Media quality will continue to be a staple in digital environments – especially on social media. With an expected 14.9% growth in ad spend on social media to reach \$306.4 billion in 2026*, media quality measurement is essential to understanding which placements are driving impact and how to optimise.

INFLUENCER MARKETING IS BECOMING INCREASINGLY IMPORTANT IN SOCIAL MEDIA

SOCIAL MEDIA

77%

of media experts agree
influencer marketing will
become an **increasingly
important** part of social
media advertising strategies

79%

of media experts say brand
safety and **suitability of the
influencer/creator** will be an
important consideration
when advertising adjacent
to social content



WHAT THIS MEANS FOR MARKETERS

Influencer marketing is growing 4x as fast as
the overall media industry.*

With growth comes challenges, and
ensuring an influencer and their content is
brand safe and suitable will be critical for
brands to feel comfortable advertising in
these environments in 2026.

INCREASING GEN AI CONTENT ON SOCIAL MEDIA IS A SIGNIFICANT CONCERN

SOCIAL MEDIA

73%

Increasing levels of AI generated content in social media will be a significant concern and will need to be monitored



81%

Third party measurement and optimisation will be important in **identifying and classifying** AI generated content within the platform



75%

Third party measurement and optimization will be important to avoid advertising **adjacent to deceptive AI content** on social media platforms



WHAT THIS MEANS FOR MARKETERS

With AI-generated content rapidly accelerating across social platforms, marketers must evolve their brand safety and suitability strategies to protect brand integrity.

Ensuring ads appear in safe, transparent environments will be a key differentiator for performance in 2026.

IAS partners with the top social media and video platforms to provide Social Optimization — a solution that puts customized, in-the-moment suitability in your hands, protecting your brand from social content you deem unsuitable while reducing waste and improving campaign performance.



CUSTOMISE FOR YOUR BRAND

Activate custom Social Optimisation inclusion and exclusion lists based on industry standard and contextual suitability categories.



ADJUST IN REAL-TIME

Get more flexibility when you need it. Social Optimisation puts the power in your hands to make real-time adjustments to your social campaigns based on actionable IAS reporting.



VALIDATE CAMPAIGNS SIMULTANEOUSLY

Pair with Total Media Quality measurement for media quality metrics that prove your optimisation is working as intended.

04

DIGITAL VIDEO

Digital video is continuing its explosive growth, commanding consumer attention across mobile and social feeds. Marketers are doubling down on this format for its massive reach and measurable impact.

Looking ahead, viewability and brand safety of ad placements in this format will remain critical to driving transparency across every screen.

[HERE'S WHAT THE EXPERTS THINK →](#)

BRAND SAFETY AND SUITABILITY OF DIGITAL VIDEO CONTENT WILL BE IMPERATIVE — ESPECIALLY AMONG INFLUENCERS

DIGITAL VIDEO

81%

of media experts say the **accelerating consumption** of social video platforms will continue to drive programmatic video ad spend

82%

of media experts agree brand safety will be a **growing concern** as the volume of digital video ads grow

89%

of media experts think brand **safety and suitability of the influencer/creator** will be an important consideration when advertising adjacent to digital video content



WHAT THIS MEANS FOR MARKETERS

As video spend grows, marketers must level up brand safety controls — especially when working with content that varies in quality and suitability. Investing in tools that measure complex video environments and ensure proper placement will be critical to protecting brand reputation.

AS DIGITAL CONTENT GROWS, THE NEED FOR INNOVATION IN ENSURING MEDIA QUALITY WITHIN DIGITAL VIDEO PLATFORMS IS ESPECIALLY IMPORTANT

DIGITAL VIDEO

77%

The ability to **identify, classify, target, and avoid** AI generated content will be needed as these types of content becomes more prevalent within digital video platforms



78%

Third party measurement and optimisation will be important to avoid digital video advertising adjacent to **deceptive AI content**



78%

Harnessing machine learning to **detect and classify** multimedia content will ensure that digital video ads are placed in brand safe and suitable environments



WHAT THIS MEANS FOR MARKETERS

Would you rather see the first and last frame of a video your ad ran adjacent to or ***every single frame***? One shows true transparency, the other only creates a blind spot for your brand.

As AI-generated video content increases, third-party measurement will play a crucial role in maintaining transparency and ensuring ads run in high-quality video environments.

Make smarter campaign decisions and maximise every dollar with IAS's Total Media Quality — a leading brand safety and suitability measurement solution for social and video platforms. Using advanced AI, Total Media Quality analyzes frame-by-frame image, audio, and text to classify content at scale.



CONSISTENT METRICS ACROSS PLATFORMS

Compare performance across platforms with consistent metrics and methodology, enabling you to maximize performance across the ecosystem.



SUITABILITY TAILORED TO YOUR BRAND

Access custom brand suitability metrics and graphs tailored to your brand that allow you to take action more effectively.



BEST-IN-CLASS TECHNOLOGY

Powered by advanced machine learning, Total Media Quality uses 100% AI to provide the most accurate measurement for the feed, at scale.



INDUSTRY-ALIGNED REPORTING

Gain valuable insights with brand safety and suitability reporting aligned to industry standards for actionable insights.

05

CONNECTED TV

Connected TV has established itself as a cornerstone of media strategies, blending the impact of linear TV with the precision of digital.

As streaming competition intensifies and ad-supported models proliferate, advertisers are demanding clearer insights into performance, reach, and quality.

[HERE'S WHAT THE EXPERTS THINK →](#)

CONCERN FOR MEDIA QUALITY IN CTV INVENTORY WILL CONTINUE TO BE PREVALENT

CONNECTED TV

84%

of media experts say that measuring attention in CTV ads will become a growing concern as marketers look for clearer indicators of campaign performance

82%

of media experts agree brand safety in CTV environments will be a growing concern as the volume of CTV inventory and the number of CTV sellers increase

76%

of media experts say ad fraud (e.g., bots, malware, spoofing) will be a greater concern as the volume of ad supported CTV inventory grows



WHAT THIS MEANS FOR MARKETERS

You might trust a premium CTV streaming platform, but what if the genre is reality TV? What about show-level: a reality show about lovers on an island. Still okay?

CTV is a fast-growing channel, but inconsistent inventory quality requires marketers to adopt CTV-specific measurement solutions. To ensure ad spend is protected, brands should prioritise partners that can provide more transparency into the quality of where CTV ads are delivered.

CTV-SPECIFIC SOLUTIONS WILL BE NEEDED TO ADDRESS MEDIA QUALITY CONCERNS IN THIS ENVIRONMENT

CONNECTED TV

83%

It will be critical for advertisers to integrate **cross-platform targeting** and tracking into CTV campaigns



79%

Harnessing machine learning to detect and classify multimedia content will ensure that CTV ads are placed in brand safe and suitable environments



76%

It will be critical for media measurement and optimization platforms to help advertisers avoid CTV **ad frequency overloads**



WHAT THIS MEANS FOR MARKETERS

As CTV matures, unifying measurement and optimisation across digital channels is essential to ensure consistent media quality and campaign performance. Establishing a holistic, quality-driven framework enables advertisers to achieve effective placements, minimise waste and ad fatigue, and maintain brand safety; regardless of where audiences engage or what screen they use.

TAKE ACTION

PRE- AND POST-BID CTV VIDEO FILTERING

CONNECTED TV

As CTV advertising continues to grow, so do threats that compromise campaign effectiveness and waste budgets. Without proper protection, your brand faces exposure to invalid traffic, geo-targeting violations, and brand safety risks that can undermine your entire advertising strategy. IAS's Post-Bid CTV Video Filtering keeps you protected.



CTV FRAUD PRE-BID

Automatically optimise away from bad actors so you can confidently bid on premium CTV inventory delivered to real humans.



INVALID TRAFFIC (IVT)

Avoid bot traffic, fraudulent impressions, non human interactions.



OUT-OF-GEO TRAFFIC

Avoid impressions from geographic locations outside of campaign targeting.



APP EXCLUSIONS

Avoid traffic from apps specifically excluded by advertiser requirements.

PRE-BID

POST-BID



06

RETAIL MEDIA NETWORKS

Retail media networks have evolved from an emerging channel to a powerhouse of digital commerce, connecting brands directly with consumers at the point of purchase.

In 2026, these networks offer unmatched data-driven precision, but also introduce new challenges around measurement, and quality assurance.

[HERE'S WHAT THE EXPERTS THINK →](#)



MEDIA QUALITY IS WIDELY CONSIDERED A FACTOR IN SUCCESS IN RETAIL MEDIA NETWORKS

RETAIL MEDIA
NETWORKS

84%

of media experts agree
measuring **attention** is an
important metric to
evaluate campaign
performance

82%

of media experts cite
viewability as an
important metric for
evaluating campaign
performance

82%

of media experts say
brand suitability will
be an important
strategy to boost
campaign
performance



WHAT THIS MEANS FOR MARKETERS

As retail media becomes a core investment channel, marketers should treat media quality as a foundational performance signal. Brands that bring the same best practices to retail media that they apply across programmatic can gain a competitive advantage in 2026.

GEN AI AND INFLUENCER CONTENT IS BECOMING A CONSIDERATION FOR AD ADJACENCY ON RETAIL MEDIA NETWORKS

78%

Brand safety and **suitability of an influencer/creator** will be an important consideration when advertising adjacent to influencer content on retail media networks

**77%**

Increasing levels of **AI generated content** in retail media networks will be a significant concern and will need to be monitored



WHAT THIS MEANS FOR MARKETERS

Retail media is rapidly expanding offsite — and this inventory isn't immune to the risks we see on the open web. Would a kids toy brand want to appear near an R-rated movie review? Probably not.

Implementing third-party measurement increases transparency so brands can avoid unsuitable environments. Taking a proactive approach can drive incremental growth, maximise ROI, and future-proof retail media investments as these formats expand.

TAKE ACTION

MEASUREMENT ON RETAIL MEDIA NETWORKS

RETAIL MEDIA
NETWORKS

Retail media is a powerhouse advertising channel, but with any emerging channel comes unforeseen challenges. Transparency can help you identify threats or media quality mishaps before they affect campaign performance and brand reputation.

And what about unlocking scale? We have a solution for that too. IAS can provide incremental reach in retail media networks by eliminating media waste while unlocking incrementally — resulting in more business outcomes for your brand.



TRANSPARENCY

Validate your campaigns and drive superior results with optimisation and measurement solutions



CONSISTENT MEASUREMENT

Compare media quality from retail media with all of your other media buys within IAS Signal



OPTIMISE FOR RESULTS

Drive performance by optimising for engagement

07

LOOKING AHEAD TO 2026

As we move into 2026, one truth is clear: the pace of digital media evolution is accelerating, and with it comes unprecedented opportunity. Social media and digital video continue to dominate consumer attention, reshaping how brands tell their stories. At the same time, generative AI is transitioning from experimental to foundational, offering new pathways for content creation and scale while also demanding rigorous oversight to ensure brand protection.

This next year will require marketers to balance innovation with transparency. The industry's growing concerns underscore how vital continued investment in media quality will be, and marketers who embrace innovative channels while maintaining strong quality controls will be best positioned for success.

IAS is at the ready to drive the industry forward with clarity and confidence, ensuring every impression brings bigger returns and better results.



08

ABOUT IAS

Integral Ad Science (IAS) is a leading global media measurement and optimisation platform that delivers the industry's most actionable data to drive superior results for the world's largest advertisers, publishers, and media platforms. IAS's software provides comprehensive and enriched data that ensures ads are seen by real people in safe and suitable environments, while improving return on ad spend for advertisers and yield for publishers. Our mission is to be the global benchmark for trust, safety, and transparency in digital media quality. For more information, visit integralads.com.

